THE GREAT SUBMARINE HUNT IS ON

INDIA'S BIG SUBMARINE ACQUISITION PROGRAMME, PROJECT 75 (I), IS ROLLING FORWARD AT FULL STEAM. WITH AN EXPANDING CHINESE SUBMARINE FLEET EXTENDING ITS REACH IN THE INDIAN OCEAN, IT MUST MOVE FASTER STILL

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ANI

Ever since they first made a deadly impact in early 20th century naval warfare, submarines have been silent and unseen guardians of the deep. Essential for navies for surveillance, tracking and pursuit, and destruction of hostile platforms, they have acquired added relevance in the nuclear age. Now, the Indian Navy is gearing up for its biggest-ever submarine acquisition programme, Project 75 (India) or P75(I). Initiated in 1997, the Rs 43,000 crore programme aims to build six advanced diesel-electric conventional submarines, equipped with better sensors, weapons and air-independent propulsion (AIP) systems through a joint venture. AIP systems allow non-nuclear submarines to stay submerged for as long as 12 days at a stretch, enhancing stealth capabilities. As per the Navy's request for proposal (RFP), the first submarine should have indigenous content of 45 per cent, which should go up to 60 per cent for the sixth submarine. Also, it stipulates that the first submarine be rolled out 84 months or seven years from the signing of the contract.

After years of deliberations with several manufacturers, Spanish state-owned firm Navantia and German company ThyssenKrupp Marine Systems (TKMS) are left in the race for the P75(I) contract. The mega-submarine deal crossed a milestone with the completion of Field Evaluation Trials (FET) to check the compliance of the submarines offered with the navy's RFP. While an Indian Navy team visited the TKMS shipyard in March for the FET, Navantia's offer was evaluated in late June.

WHAT IS PROJECT 75 (I)?

- India's biggest submarine acquisition programme is being given a huge upgrade
- Under the Rs 43,000 crore project, India will build six diesel electric subs through a joint venture
- The first submarine will have indigenous content of 45%, to go up to 60% for the sixth